

NOTES ON CONTRIBUTORS

WILLIAM EMPSON, according to word recently received from him by his British publisher, has continued in his teaching position in Peking throughout the recent crisis, and proposes to remain there.

CAROLINE GORDON, in collaboration with her husband, Allen Tate, has just completed *The House of Fiction* ("An Anthology, with Commentaries"), and is at work on her seventh novel, to be called *The Strange Children*.

FREDERICK J. HOFFMAN, author of *Freudianism and the Literary Mind* and co-author of *The Little Magazine*, teaches English at the University of Wisconsin.

P. M. PASINETTI, a previous contributor, is at present at Yale, engaged in research in comparative literature.

PHILIP MURRAY lives in Philadelphia; his poems have appeared in *Chicago Review*, *The Tiger's Eye*, and other periodicals.

RICHARD ELLMANN has recently published *William Butler Yeats: The Man and the Masks*; a selection from his translations of the work of Henri Michaux was published in *The Sewanee Review* for Winter, 1948.

EDWARD MCGEHEE, on leave from the faculty of the University of Minnesota, at present holds a Rosenwald Fellowship, and is in Paris working on a novel.

JOHN EDWARD HARDY has recently completed, with Cleanth Brooks, a book on Milton; he is a member of the Department of English of the University of Oklahoma.

WILLIAM HUMPHREY reports: "I am 24, a Texan, attended Southern Methodist University and the University of Texas. I make my living as a farmhand."

JACKSON MATHEWS, recently returned from his post as U. S. Cultural Attaché in Switzerland, is a member of the Department of Modern Languages in Princeton University. His translation of Valéry's *Monsieur Teste* was published by Knopf in 1947.

HAROLD H. WATTS, a previous contributor, teaches English at Purdue University.

GIACOMO LEOPARDI

By P. M. PASINETTI

IN a peripheral region of the Papal domains, in a family by all means orthodox and strict but not without the culture and some of the awkward warmth and mutual devotion of high-ranking and pious provincials, a young man had the spirit, and the love of form, to address to his sister on the occasion of her projected marriage six firmly composed stanzas of which, for example, the second begins: "You will have either miserable or cowardly children. Choose miserable." This man, this young poet, Leopardi, physically very weak, by birth and circumstances of life a nobleman and an intellectual, in temperament extremely capable of tenderness, establishes in the early part of the Nineteenth Century a voice, a tone, wherein we find it singularly difficult to detect any indulgence in the "heroics" of personal sorrow. The sorrowful hero which we can, so to speak, deduce from his various poetic inventions, from the various speakers of his poems (*Canti*), and characters in his prose pieces (*Operette Morali*, etc.), is not the self-listening and self-pitying variety. He is not making a display of his feeling, is not like so many poets of the romantic *Stimmung*, counting on it as a source of pleasure. In some of his best moments he gives, even syntactically, the impression of having come, not without reluctance, to certain definite conclusions, from which, as he appears to imply with a sort of desperate gentleness, there is no visible escape. He is no *enfant du siècle* not only because he is too solitary, too clearly deprived of a conventional sense of the *siècle* on one side and, on the other, of an audience for which it may be worth playing the part; but also because he is prevented from assuming the role by what I would call again a sense of form; and

by a sense of lucidity, inevitability, and seriousness, and by a consequent attitude which I tentatively call *verecundia*. In this direction, probably, we should look for some of the reasons why the most recent translator of some of his poems, John Heath-Stubbs,* finds that "in some respects . . . he stands closer to our own age" than any of the "typical Romantics": because for one thing, to put it roughly, sorrow in our time can allow itself anything but the comforts of being self-listening and pleasurable.

Obviously these facts, on the individual texts, could be examined for what they are, verbal operations, suggesting problems of attitude and tone, problems of what again, with rather careless critical manners, we may refer to as form. More than once the slogan which we heard used about Leopardi is that he has romantic themes, but couched in classical shapes. And doubtful as those terms are, they do try to register the fact that the verbal discipline is, in Leopardi, a very significant thing. Rather than of his immediate contemporaries we happen to think of a later, and so very different poet, Baudelaire: in both cases, style, the presence of the organizing sense of discipline and *métier*, becomes something of a moral fact: there is a moral force in the very idea of performing something very well and very firmly in circumstances which are neither good nor firm. The performance of the poetic act becomes the supreme symbol of permanence in change, and even more, of validity amid worthlessness.

A guarantee, however unnecessary, of Leopardi's seriousness in this sense is to be seen in his relative literary isolation, which gives his voice, in his literary age and milieu, its authentic timbre of solitude. I have already suggested that he had at his disposal no audience particularly prepared to receive a poet's sorrowful outpourings, no public temper of which he could be the vibrating cord. The solitariness of some important Romantics presupposes instead, somewhat paradoxically, an audi-

**Poems from Giacomo Leopardi*. Translated and introduced by John Heath-Stubbs. London, John Lehmann; New York, New Directions. 1948. \$3.00.

ence, a background against which the poet's isolation may show itself sharply and heroically. In what I believe is an old scholastic parallel between Leopardi and another aristocrat of the period, Vigny, we should by no means neglect the significant differences in this respect. They are instructive. It seems natural to take Vigny also because he is one of the writers who most consistently divulged myths of poetic isolation, using, for instance, the Chatterton legend twice. Once in a letter he wrote that the poem which expressed him best, if any did, was *Moïse*; now, a line chosen almost at random from that poem,

J'ai marché devant tous, triste et seul dans ma gloire,

is possibly the kind of thing which Leopardi would be least likely to be found writing. Moïse's solitude is realized with reference to a people of which he is the leader; the burden from which he begs to be delivered is that of vast solitary power, a power which, as is not rarely the case with the Romantics, seems to consist also of some sort of cosmic knowledge, which the poetry on such occasions states rather sweepingly: the hero knows the secrets of the skies, he has torn the veils of night, and the stars follow his command. One of Leopardi's best known poetic figures is the young shepherd wandering through Asia (the poem "Night Song" is among Mr. Heath-Stubbs's translations); and he too has a relationship to moon and stars. From the character chosen, it would seem inevitable to expect an even subtler power than that of Moïse, the power which is associated with the romantic type of the primitive and intuitive being or child-seer. Leopardi's figure has three attributes which would warrant such expectations: he is a youth, a shepherd, and an Oriental. He turns out to be anything but the *Genie*. There are many ways to put this. One way would be to see the function of some of the basic images: the moon, for instance, that central romantic emblem. Here the moon, and not the gazer,

is the carrier of cosmic knowledge; to the shepherd, in his contemplation of the vain motions of the sky, that knowledge is impenetrable. The untarnished candor of the *giovinetta immortale*, virginal, all-knowing, and revealing nothing, seems to stand for an enviable condition in which infinite knowledge and infinite unawareness coincide: a state both of total fulfillment and sublime absence. Or, to put this perhaps less pretentiously, the poet feels an always renewed, always frustrated necessity of illusion and questioning, and thence he speaks, whereas the moon is silent: the common attributes, *silenziosa, muta*, acquire special pertinence here. As a parable of poetic solitude, then, the poem does not present the customary pattern of isolation in some kind of superiority: even the power of the imagination, so trustworthy and advertised among the Romantics, is questioned and, in a final gesture, rejected. And, here and elsewhere, this capacity for the supreme rejection is what makes somehow the moments of illusion so valid in their precariousness, ready to fall, as they are, under what I would call a mental discipline of hopelessness—a discipline which is, in a deep sense, a sign of basic and authentic toughness. What remains after the fall, more tangibly than ever, is the poem, the poetic act: this self-justifying offering, ready to renew itself, wherein the discipline of form acquires, as we were saying, singular significance.

Certain facts, talking of form and craftsmanship, cannot of course be conveyed in description or translation, a difficulty of which Mr. Heath-Stubbs for instance is undoubtedly aware, and which makes his loving labor even more commendable. Leopardi in several of his best poems takes the *canzone*, an august Italian form, and uses it freely. Lines of various lengths (particularly of seven and eleven syllables) are used in a varied interplay of end-rhymes and internal rhymes, and patterned in lays which also vary in length: the whole structure permits passages of discursive fluency or, at times, of a broken, questioning kind of phrasing concluded perhaps by some hard-falling, closely

rhymed short couplet. The general feeling is one of continuous control over the modulation of the voice: a voice capable of combining a sense of hardness and finality with one of natural discourse and with a kind of gracefulness.

In general terms, what I think we might say Leopardi did was to adapt canons of classical writing and intonation to new usage; and he did so not only for poetry, but for prose as well. In a special sense, he sniffed at progress and modernity. But in the body of his work the philosophic spirit, in the eighteenth-century sense of the expression, with its large interests and its communicative style, is not rejected, but is rather assumed, digested, reckoned with. He often seems to have been taken for the type of the dreamy recluse, or of the retiring wretch, but those images do not really hold even biographically; he was extraordinarily *au courant*, and his prose is an instrument very much adapted to make us aware of that. The kind of syntax that in others would be ponderous, acquires in him a tone of inescapable, persuasive reasoning, and yet of gentleness and vivacity; it has a firmly disciplined core and somehow the discipline brings forth more clearly its variety and inventiveness. If we may broadly generalize and say that a sense of form and proportion is an inevitable ingredient in the Italian genius, we might say that Leopardi rescued that sense from the dangers of academism and thus left a message which is both stylistic and moral. For at his best, he is the kind of writer for whom the handling of language, the manner in which he performs, is one and the same thing with his view of human affairs and his forcefulness in defining the human state.

As we suggested at the beginning, nothing could be more alien to that sense of form than gesticulation or even simple posturing. What is essential in his upholding the Greek and Latin literary tradition against his view of the Romantics of the north, is that he saw in classical literature the total absence of affectation. The adjective "natural" is a key-word in practically

all men of letters in the Eighteenth and Nineteenth Centuries, and it has dozens of meanings; Leopardi applies it to his view of the ancients, and particularly of the ancients as writers, whose voices were familiar to him since childhood, when, in his stunning precociousness, he ruined his health and his eyesight in his father's library. In our days, when in the dwindling classical curricula of our schools we are perhaps saluting the last remnants of direct familiarity with the classics, it is quite attractive to see how firmly and quietly he stood by them, how, in other words, they provided the main substance for his allegiance to the profession of letters.

That allegiance was maintained also against what may seem now scarcely encouraging circumstances. Anyone in that position (and the pattern could be amplified and adapted, in a sense, to the status of Italian literature in the world) runs the danger of being confused with the pedants; and when the quarrel between Classics and Romantics was widely advertised and fashionable, that confusion must have been extremely likely. It would be quite inconsiderate to perpetuate it. It is true that some of the people who knew and admired him most (Germans, for instance, like Niebuhr and Bunsen) saw first of all his immense erudition; but this evidently seemed preferable to being confused with what he considered flimsy fashion. His stand against the current fads, as he shows for instance in the *Discourse by an Italian on Romantic Poetry* written at twenty (and containing at the end, as some of his poetry of that period, a rather bookish vision of the *patria*) was partly inspired by the necessity of rescuing the classic spirit from the effects of that type of polemic which consists in producing a caricature of the adversary and abusing it while appropriating his virtues and sticking new and fashionable labels on them. The Romantics, he insists for example, did not invent what they call the pathetic; and their terms can be as absurd and pedantic as those of the old rhetoricians. In this connection it is also important

to see, in Leopardi's attitude toward classic example, what I would call its domestic tone: it literally formed his early life, not so much in the sense of scholastic discipline, as in the sense that early life is the age of fantasy and fable. The parallel between the ancient world and every man's childhood, so vastly theorized by so many, was probably to him as much of a natural experience as it has ever been to anyone. In the *Discourse* which we have mentioned, after having confronted with a kind of impetuous common sense the problem of poetic and intellectual belief, he has an eloquent vision of the childhood of the world, transposed to the level of autobiography, "for what the ancients were, we have all been for some years . . . partaking of that ignorance and those fears and those beliefs and that boundless operation of fantasy." His main theme, we might say, is the acceptance of the fall of that world and of all it symbolizes; and he is therefore among the first to conceive of poetry in a pattern of irretrievable loss, adumbrating the idea that modern poetry has its main source in that sense of loss, is somehow made possible only by it, and acquires its validity there.

All we know about Leopardi confirms in him a correspondingly clear and unpretentious allegiance to poetry and to the profession of letters. A man who was hailed in his lifetime as a great philologist and who had a sharp sense not only for the practice of language but for visualizing its position and problems in human intercourse; who considered "poetry the peak of language, and the lyric the peak of poetry," and who wrote elsewhere in his notebooks that "man hates inactivity and wants to be liberated from it by the arts," obviously felt that his main allegiance was to the word. His vision of the classical heritage in relation to intuitive feeling and poetic illusion could be elaborated on, and debated from various angles. The particular thing we want to stress here is the fact that that vision never transcended to the blazing and often easy-going statements about poetry as supernatural power, magic, sorcery. In fact, in his

view of the ancients there seems to be implied the feeling that they enviably took poetry for granted among human activities and crafts; and in this sense, rather than in that of uncontrolled sentimentalism, words like "natural" or "spontaneous" should be understood.

And also in this sense we understand why Leopardi's isolation has nothing morbid and defiant about it. His concept of the place of poetry is such that it does not make poetry sound as though it were on the defensive, either begrudging its own loneliness or blatantly advertising itself as something other than poetry. What makes the reading of many of his literary statements, in spite of occasional repetitiousness or naïveté, so interesting and so reassuring, is among other things the sense that he deals with subjects which he comfortably possesses and whose importance is unquestioned and can be unexcitedly implied. In stating the power of poetry and the inevitable recurrence of the poetic act, his eloquence is so temperate that it has a tone of lucid definition: "The very knowledge of the irreparable vanity and falsity of all beauty and greatness fills the soul with beauty and greatness when such knowledge is found in the works of genius. The very spectacle of nothingness seems to enlarge and heighten the reader's soul. . . ." (The notebook entry is of October, 1820, and the passage has a conclusive and significant allusion to the great star of the day: "And certainly Lord Byron did not make me any more sensitive to my own desperation: he rather made me more insensitive and marmoreal.")

Arts and letters were far from being his only concern; he had clearly the variety of interests of the whole man of the Romantics, and his notebooks, known as *Zibaldone* and consisting of over 4,500 pages of manuscript, have also been used for collections of excerpts of all kinds, the latest I saw being one of *Anarchic Thoughts*. But our focus here is on his position as writer and on his own sense of that position. It resisted, quietly, against all odds. It may seem absurd to some if we conceive of

the history of literature in terms of the history of the literary profession, and speculate on the opportunities and on the missed chances which that history continuously presents. But there is no doubt that a functioning milieu, and some ferment of interchange between speaker and audience, have their weight even for the writers of the most exclusive and self-reliant temperaments. More so in the case of Leopardi, who had the makings of an influential man of letters and even of a stirring literary journalist in the better sense. His biography, in spite of a few deep friendships therein recorded, reads largely as a story of discomfort and illness, of ill-arranged publishers' contracts, of positions somewhat lazily coveted by him and finally obtained by colorless competitors, and of relations, now tense, now tender or awkward, with the provincial family. I suppose it would be customary to conclude that his place in the native *Recanati* and in the various and generally unsatisfactory and provincial milieux which he knew luckily created one of those situations, perhaps typical of Italy, where nothing seems to exist between the domestic and the cosmic. But we cannot help thinking on the other hand that the main bulk of his prose remained unpublished until long after his death. His plans were many, and the response they encountered was very small indeed. At the risk of sounding frivolous, we may even record the impression that he could have given us one of the most important and attractive novels of the century. He wrote of it little more than one sentence. But we keep thinking of his love for the *pastiche*, his facility in assuming voices and masks, certain fragments of autobiography which read like internal monologues, and all the things which testify to his ability and gusto in the invention of character, from the days of childhood ("fables told Carlo Sunday mornings in bed,") to the time of early youth when he spent his days in the paternal library and invented a Greek poet.

His *Zibaldone* was really explored only comparatively recently when Italian writers, especially through it, re-discovered

Leopardi's voice, a voice in many ways pertinent and unique, and made his example available to themselves and to their time in terms of its needs, tendencies, and vices. In a partly different sense, a reopening of the Leopardi account could be desirable outside of Italy as well.